Fantasy Basketball Draft Kit 2026-27

Draft to win now: tiered cheat-sheet rankings, sleepers and busts, auction dollar values, printable draft board for the 2026-27 season.

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CHAPTER 1

Chapter 1: Read This First: How to Use the Kit in Your Draft

This kit is built to be used live, not read once and shelved. Here's how the pieces fit together.

Before Your Draft

- Set your format first. Roto, head-to-head categories, and points leagues value players differently. Read Chapter 3 and mark which strategy applies to you before you touch the rankings.
- Print the draft board. Chapter 8 has a printable board and tracking sheet. Fill in your league's roster slots and budget before draft day so you're not doing setup math on the clock.
- Highlight your cheat sheet. In Chapter 2, circle every player you'd realistically draft. Cross out anyone you won't roster. A 200-name sheet narrowed to 90 is faster to scan mid-draft.

During the Draft

- Draft by tier, not by rank. When your pick comes up, take the highest-ranked player remaining in a tier you still need. If a tier is about to run dry, reach one pick early.
- Track runs. When three players at one position go in five picks, expect the next tier to follow. The tracking sheet has a column for this.
- Keep the sleeper list open. Chapter 5 names late-round targets with clear paths to minutes. Check it in the final rounds instead of defaulting to a name you recognize.

After the Draft

- Note your punts. If you're punting categories (Chapter 4), write down which ones on the tracking sheet. It shapes every waiver add and trade.
- Set your first waiver claim before Week 1 tips off, using Chapter 9's priority guidance.

What This Kit Won't Do

It won't tell you a player is guaranteed to break out. Rankings are informed projections, not promises. Your job is to use the tiers, prices, and checklists to make faster, more consistent decisions than the managers around you.

CHAPTER 2

Chapter 2: Tiered Cheat Sheet: Rankings by Position and Overall

Tiers beat a flat ranking list because they tell you when to reach and when to wait. A rank says "this player is 34th." A tier says "the last player in this group is about to go, so take yours now or lose the group."

How to Build Your Sheet

1. Rank players by projected per-game value in your scoring format first, then adjust for games played. A player who misses 20 games is worth less than his per-game line suggests.
2. Group players whose value is within roughly one round of each other into a tier. If you would be equally happy with any of four names, they belong in one tier.
3. Label each tier with a draft range, not a rank: "Tier 2 — picks 12–24," "Tier 3 — picks 25–40."
4. Keep a separate positional sheet. Use it to see scarcity: if only two starting centers remain in Tier 3, your next center pick is now or never.

Reading the Sheet in the Draft

- When a tier's last player comes off the board, move immediately. Do not wait for "value" at a position where the tier just emptied.
- When three or more players remain in your tier at a pick, take the best player available and let the tier come to you next round.
- Cross off names as they go. A tiered sheet only works if you can see at a glance what is left.

Positional vs. Overall

Draft from the overall sheet, but check the positional sheet before every pick in rounds 4–8. That is where runs start and where a tier you were counting on disappears in three picks.

CHAPTER 3

Chapter 3: Draft Strategy by Format: Roto, Head-to-Head, and Points Leagues

Format changes what a stat is worth. Before you rank anyone, confirm your league's settings and draft to them.

Roto: Volume and Balance

- Value players by total season output. A player who plays 78 games beats a similar per-game producer who plays 60.
- Track category scarcity as you draft. If you're behind in blocks by Round 8, reach for a rim protector before the tier empties.
- Avoid overloading one category. Winning steals by a wide margin wastes value you could have spent on assists.
- Draft at least one high-assist guard and one high-block big in the first six rounds to keep every category live.

Head-to-Head: Weekly Matchups

- Prioritize games played per week. Players on teams with four-game weeks in your playoff window are worth more.
- Target category specialists you can stream around. In H2H, winning 5–4 every week beats chasing 9–0 once.
- Check your league's playoff schedule before the draft. Stack players whose teams play four games in your league's championship weeks.
- Punt one or two categories you can reliably lose and build strengths elsewhere.

Points Leagues

- Ignore category balance entirely. Rank by projected points per game and total points.
- Weight scoring settings: if your league rewards 3-pointers heavily, shooters gain value; if it penalizes turnovers, avoid high-usage ball handlers.
- Volume scorers and high-minute starters rise; category specialists who don't score fall.
- Use per-game scoring averages from your platform's projections, not generic rankings.

Format Checklist

- Confirm category or points settings before Round 1.
- Note your playoff weeks and each star's schedule.
- Adjust your cheat sheet tiers for format before you're on the clock.

CHAPTER 4

Chapter 4: Punting Categories: Building a Roto Roster That Wins Five Cats

Punting means deliberately conceding one or two categories to concentrate talent in the other seven or eight. In a standard 9-cat league, winning five categories outright and finishing mid-pack in the rest beats a balanced roster that finishes third everywhere.

Step 1: Pick Your Punt Before the Draft, Not During It

Choose one category to punt based on what the draft room is undervaluing. Common punts and the stats they free you from chasing:

- Punt FT%: target high-volume bigs and slashing guards who get to the line but shoot poorly. You gain rebounds, blocks, and FG%.
- Punt assists: load up on scorers, rebounders, and shot-blockers. Guards who don't pass become assets.
- Punt blocks: stack guards and wings with steals and threes.
- Punt turnovers: accept high-usage stars whose turnover rate is ugly.

Pick exactly one punt. Two punts means you must win six of seven remaining categories to break even, which is a thin margin.

Step 2: Check the Punt Fits Your First-Round Pick

Your punt must be compatible with the best player available at your slot. If you take a guard who shoots 90% from the line in Round 1, punting FT% wastes that value. List your punt on your draft board and cross off any player whose strengths you'd be throwing away.

Step 3: Fill the Punt's Categories Last

- Rounds 1–6: draft the best player available who fits your punt.

- Rounds 7–10: target specialists in the categories you're chasing (a blocks-and-rebounds center, a steals-and-threes wing).
- Final rounds: add one player who can swing a close category, even at the cost of your punt stat.

Step 4: Track Your Category Count Mid-Draft

After every three picks, tally projected totals in each of the eight categories you're keeping. If you're projected to win fewer than five, adjust: your punt is failing and you need to either abandon it or trade up in a category.

CHAPTER 5

Chapter 5: Sleepers: Late-Round Targets With Clear Paths to Minutes

A sleeper is not a good player. It is a player whose projected minutes are underpriced by the draft room. The room drafts last season's role; you draft this season's role.

The Three-Part Minutes Test

Run every late-round candidate through this filter. Skip any player who fails a step.

1. Vacated minutes. Who left the rotation, and how many minutes per game did they play? A team that lost a 30-minute starter has a real hole. A team returning its top eight rotation players does not.
2. Depth-chart blockers. Count the players ahead of your candidate who logged more minutes per game last season and are still on the roster. One blocker is workable. Two means you are drafting an injury away from nothing.
3. Contract and draft capital. Teams give minutes to players they are invested in. A recent first-round pick or a player on a new multi-year deal gets a longer leash than a minimum-salary veteran. This is a tiebreaker, not a guarantee.

Where Late-Round Minutes Hide

- The post-trade rebuild. Teams that moved a veteran starter in the offseason hand the role to the next man up. Check every team that made a win-now trade for a rotation player.
- The second-year leap. Rookies who finished the prior season logging 20-plus minutes per game often start the next season in a bigger role. The draft room remembers the slow start, not the finish.
- The coaching change. A new coach with no loyalty to the old rotation is the single best source of underpriced minutes.
- The position switch. A big man who added a three-point shot or a guard asked to play more off-ball can unlock minutes that did not exist last year.

How to Draft Them

- Take one sleeper per position, not four at the same position.
- Pair each sleeper with a safe starter at the same position so a lost minutes battle does not sink your roster.
- In head-to-head leagues, prioritize sleepers with early-season opportunity; you can cut them by December.
- In roto leagues, prioritize sleepers whose path is a full-season role, not a temporary injury fill-in.

Red Flags That Disqualify a Sleeper

- Two established players ahead of him on the depth chart.
- A player who has never logged 20 minutes per game in the NBA.
- A team with no offseason departures from its rotation.
- A summer-league standout with no regular-season minutes on record.

Your final two or three picks should be sleepers who pass all three tests, not name-brand veterans in decline.

CHAPTER 6

Chapter 6: Busts: Overpriced Names to Let Someone Else Draft

A bust in this chapter is not a bad player. It's a player whose average draft position (ADP) assumes a role, workload, or health outcome that isn't supported. You don't draft busts; you let the room pay for them.

The Four Bust Signals

Before the draft, flag any player who shows two or more of these:

- Role change: A starter who lost his job, or a veteran whose team drafted his replacement. Check projected starting lineups, not last year's stat line.
- Minutes cliff: A player over 32 whose minutes per game fell after the All-Star break. Age plus declining minutes is the most reliable fade signal.
- Usage drop: Falling usage rate or shot attempts after a teammate's return or a midseason trade. Usage predicts counting stats better than reputation.
- Injury pattern: Multiple soft-tissue injuries (hamstring, calf, groin) in the past two seasons, or a surgery with a vague return timeline. Recurrence risk is real; don't pay full price for it.

How to Fade Without Fighting the Room

1. Set a hard price. For each flagged name, write the most you'd pay in auction dollars or the round you'd take him. Never exceed it, even if he's the last "name" on the board.
2. Let him go early, then trade later. If a bust candidate starts slowly, his manager will often sell low by midseason. That's when you buy at a discount.
3. Draft the replacement, not the vacancy. If a star's absence opens minutes, target the backup's backup at a fraction of the cost.

4. Keep a "do not draft" list of five names. Write it on your draft board. Cross off each one as someone else takes him.

The Trap to Avoid

Do not fade a player just because he's old or boring. Fade him because his price assumes something the evidence doesn't support. A 34-year-old with stable minutes and a clear role is not a bust; he's often a value.

CHAPTER 7

Chapter 7: Auction Dollar Values: Pricing Every Tier and Budgeting Your Bids

Turn Your Rankings Into Dollar Values

Auction budgets need one number per player, not a ranking. Use this method on draft morning:

1. Pick your league's budget (standard is $200) and count roster spots you must fill. If you keep $1 per bench slot, your "spendable pool" is budget minus bench slots.
2. Assign each player a projected stat line from your cheat sheet (Chapter 2), then rank the top 100 by total value across your league's categories.
3. Convert ranks to dollars: take the spendable pool, subtract a $1 floor for every roster spot, and distribute the remainder across the top 60–70 players in descending order. The top 10 usually absorb roughly 40% of the pool — check that your list reflects that shape.
4. Round to the nearest dollar and write the number next to each name on your sheet.

Tier Pricing Rules

- Tier 1 (top 8): expect $55–$75 in a $200 league. Never bid past your number by more than $3.
- Tier 2 (ranks 9–25): $30–$50. This is where value leaks — most rooms overpay for last year's names.
- Tier 3 (ranks 26–50): $12–$28. Your profit margin lives here.
- Tier 4 (ranks 51–90): $2–$10. Nominate these early to drain other managers' budgets.
- Bench: $1 each. Never pay $2 for a player you can win at $1 later.

Budgeting Your Bids

- Split your budget: about 70% on your first four buys, 25% on the next four, 5% held back for endgame $1 bids.

- Track remaining dollars and remaining roster spots on paper after every sale. If dollars divided by open spots drops below $1, you are in trouble.
- Nominate players you don't want, especially in tiers where you already have a buy. Let others spend.
- Set a hard cap per player before bidding starts and stop when you hit it.

CHAPTER 8

Chapter 8: Printable Draft Board and In-Draft Tracking Sheet

Build the Board Before Draft Day

Print two copies: one for the wall, one for your desk.

1. Grid setup. Draw a grid with one column per team and one row per round (13 rounds for a standard 13-round, 12-team league). Write team names across the top in draft order. If you pick 7th, mark your column.
2. Color-code your tiers. Fill each cell with the player as he comes off the board, but shade your own picks with a highlighter. This shows your roster construction at a glance — three guards and no center is visible immediately.
3. Position tags. Write a one-letter position code (G, F, C) next to each name. When you're on the clock, scan your shaded column for gaps.
4. Cross off the cheat sheet. Keep your tiered cheat sheet (Chapter 2) beside the board and strike through every drafted name. The board is the record; the cheat sheet is the decision tool.

The In-Draft Tracking Sheet

Use a single page with these columns:

- Round / Pick number
- Player taken
- Position
- My roster count by position (running tally: PG, SG, SF, PF, C)
- Category flags — mark the cats you still need (e.g., "3PM," "BLK," "FT%")

Update the running tally after every pick, not just your own. Knowing which categories your leaguemates have already cornered tells you what will still be available two rounds from now.

Rules That Prevent Panic Picks

- Pick from your tier, not your gut. If two players in the same tier are available, take the one who fills a flagged category.
- Never reach more than one tier. If your target is gone, move to the next name on the same tier list; don't jump two tiers for a "name."
- Track runs, don't chase them. When five straight point guards go, check your board — that run means value is falling at other positions, not that you must take a guard.
- Leave the last two rounds blank on purpose. Those picks are for upside and handcuffs; decide them live.

CHAPTER 9

Chapter 9: In-Season Levers: Waiver Priority, Streaming, and Trade Windows

Your draft is one input. The managers who win in March are the ones who use the waiver wire, stream roster spots, and time their trades. Here's the operating manual.

Waiver Priority: Spend It Like a Budget

- In FAAB leagues, set a per-week budget at the start of the season and log every bid. A common split: 70% of your budget reserved for the first six weeks, 30% held for injury fallout.
- In rolling-priority leagues, your claim order is a resource. Don't burn a top-3 claim on a player who will clear waivers and sign as a free agent anyway. If the player is likely to go unclaimed, wait.
- Claim rule of thumb: bid on a player only if he'll start for you within two weeks. Bench depth that never cracks your lineup is wasted priority.

Streaming: Own the Schedule, Not the Name

- Identify your two weakest roster slots. Stream those, not your core.
- Stream by games played, not by talent. A player with four games in a week beats a better player with two.
- Set a weekly routine: Sunday night, map your streamer slots for the coming week against the schedule. Monday morning, execute.
- Don't stream in roto unless you're chasing a specific category late. In head-to-head, stream aggressively.

Trade Windows: When Leverage Peaks

- Early season (Weeks 1-4): Buy low on slow starters. Managers overreact to small samples. Target players with stable roles but cold shooting.

- Midseason: This is when standings gaps create motivated sellers. Identify the manager chasing a category you can spare.
- Trade deadline: Know your league's deadline date now, not in February. Work backward two weeks to start conversations.
- Never propose a trade without checking the other roster's category needs. A fair trade that doesn't fill a hole gets rejected.

The Checklist

- Log every FAAB bid and waiver claim.
- Review your streamer slots every Sunday.
- Note your league's trade deadline on day one.
- Check opposing rosters before every trade offer.

CHAPTER 10

Chapter 10: Last-Minute Draft-Day Checklist and Final Round Plan

Two Hours Before the Draft

Run this list in order. Do not skip items because you feel ready.

- Confirm your league settings in the platform: number of teams, roster slots, scoring format, waiver type, and IR spots. Settings change between seasons more often than people assume.
- Re-sort your tiered cheat sheet against those settings. A points-league sheet is not a roto sheet.
- Check injury news one final time. Cross off any player with a designation that has no return timeline.
- Verify your queue or pre-rank list is loaded if the platform supports it, as a backup if you disconnect.
- Print or open the tracking sheet from Chapter 8. Have a pen if you are drafting offline.
- Test your connection and log in early. Have the league app open on a second device.

Your Final Round Plan

The last two rounds are for players who can earn minutes now, not names you hope develop. Before the draft, write down six names in priority order. Use these criteria:

- A clear path to 20-plus minutes, either through a thin depth chart or an injury ahead of them.
- At least one category where they already produce at an NBA level.
- No blocked rotation spot behind two established players.

Draft from that list in order. If all six are gone, take the highest-usage player remaining on a bad team rather than a low-usage player on a contender.

After Your Last Pick

- Screenshot your full roster.
- Note your two weakest categories. Those drive your first waiver claims in week one.
- Set a reminder to check injury reports the morning of your league's first games.